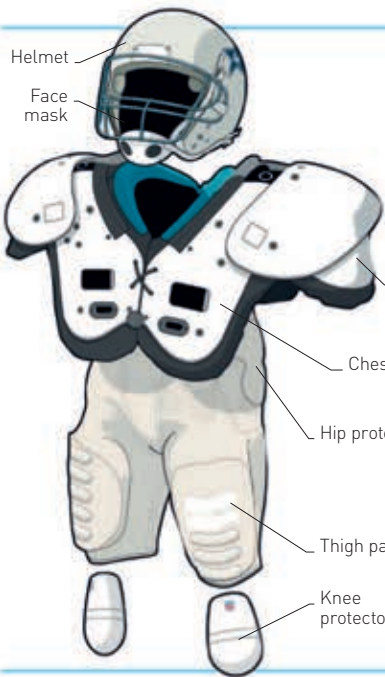


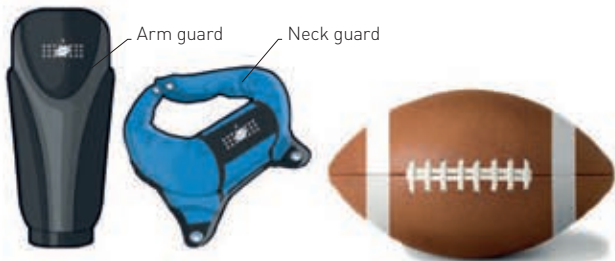
# American football

Also known as gridiron in some countries, American football is one of the most popular sports in the United States. Professional football (the NFL) and college football are the most popular forms of the game.



## EQUIPMENT

American football is a full-contact sport. Every part of the body needs to be protected against charging players. A helmet is the most vital piece of kit, as head clashes in a game are common. Players also wear body armour worn over soft shock-pads, which absorb any hard blows; this gives them a top-heavy appearance.



### PADDING

A range of pads can be worn to protect specific parts of the body. The sort of protection a player wears often depends on the position in which he or she plays.

### THE BALL

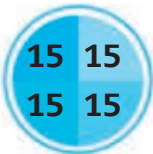
The ball is oval in shape. It is 28 cm (11 in) long, has a circumference of 71 cm (28 in) at its widest point, and weighs 425 g (15 oz).

## THE GAME

Two teams of 11 players compete during four periods of play (known as "quarters"). The aim is to score points by advancing an oval ball into an opponent's end zone (to score a touchdown) or by kicking it through the goal posts (to score a field goal).



LASTS  
60 MINUTES



4 QUARTERS OF  
15 MINUTES



HAS 2 TEAMS OF  
11 PLAYERS

## SCORING POINTS

The objective in American football is to score more points than the opposition. Points can be scored in five ways.

### TOUCHDOWN

A touchdown is scored if a team advances the ball into the opponent's end zone. The ball can either be run over the line or passed to a teammate in the end zone. A touchdown is the game's most valuable scoring play, worth six points.

### POINT AFTER TOUCHDOWN

After a touchdown, a team can score an extra point by kicking the ball through the goal posts.

### TWO POINT CONVERSION

Teams do not have to opt for a kick after scoring a touchdown. Instead, they could opt to score a try. In this instance, the team has a single play to score a touchdown. If successful, the team is awarded an extra two points.

### FIELD GOAL

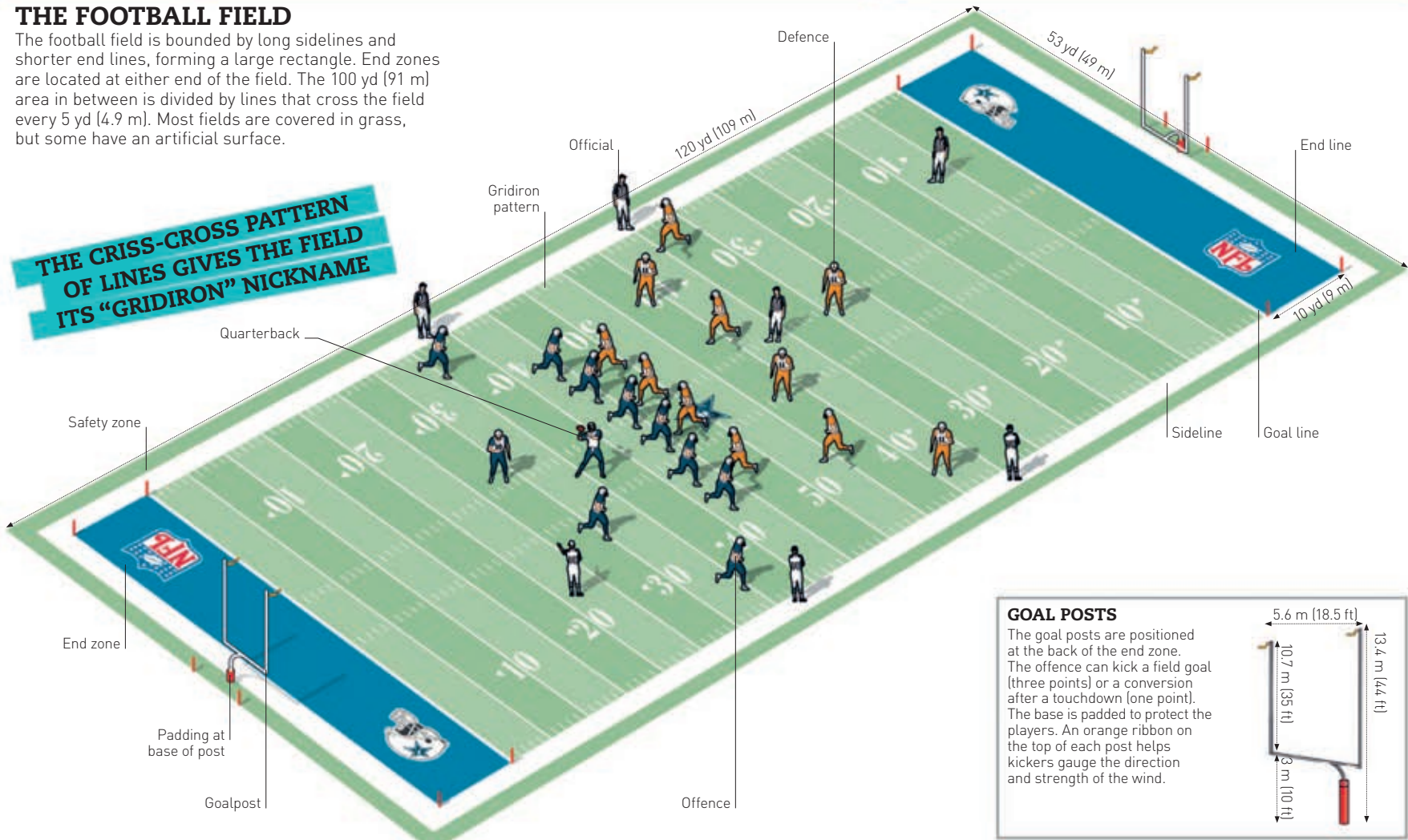
A field goal is scored when the ball is kicked through the goal posts. It is worth three points.

### SAFETY

A safety, worth two points, is awarded if an opponent is tackled or spills the ball in his own end zone and it goes out of play.

## THE FOOTBALL FIELD

The football field is bounded by long sidelines and shorter end lines, forming a large rectangle. End zones are located at either end of the field. The 100 yd (91 m) area in between is divided by lines that cross the field every 5 yd (4.9 m). Most fields are covered in grass, but some have an artificial surface.



### GOAL POSTS

The goal posts are positioned at the back of the end zone. The offence can kick a field goal (three points) or a conversion after a touchdown (one point). The base is padded to protect the players. An orange ribbon on the top of each post helps kickers gauge the direction and strength of the wind.

